recognition and a Laxmi Menon became a standard of beauty in her own right. It did little though for the dark-skinned girl in the marriage market. Wedding website shaadi.com even had a Fitzpatrick scale of sorts for Indian skin tones, till universal outrage forced them to take it down.

Marriage is not the end of that discrimination. A 2021 study in Sage Journals by Reena Kukreja of Queens University in Canada surveyed 57 villages across four Indian states—Haryana, Rajasthan, Odisha and West Bengal—to find out if the skin tone affected the married life of people from 'darker' states who married those from the 'fairer' northern states. Of the 100-plus women who were interviewed, half reported colourism, or frequently being called '*kala kauwwa*' (black crow) or '*kaali nagin*' (black serpent). The families they married into attributed their skin colour to being from the 'inferior' castes, even impure. Some of them even reported being barred from eating with the family, or even cooking for them.



"With the pressure to conform to a certain 'idea' of what is beautiful, young children really struggle to fit in and socialise, with those who don't conform getting subjected to typecasting"

UPASANA CHADDHA
Psychologist

Colourism spilled into work spaces too, the bias most visible in appearance-focused industries such as tourism and hospitality, aviation, retail, media and entertainment. Indian films are replete with examples of dark-skinned women being cast in tertiary, stereotypical roles, seldom the leads (see *Fifty Shades of Prejudice*). The world of classical arts is not immune to the malaise either. Last year, classical dancer Kalamandalam Sathyabhama drew widespread criticism for making derogatory remarks against Mohiniyattam dancer R.L.V. Ramakrishnan, who was from a Dalit background. Comparing his complexion to that of a crow, she deemed him unfit for that graceful genre of dance saying only "fair-skinned, good-looking men" are eligible to perform it. Ramakrishnan was later appointed assistant professor at the Kerala Kalamandalam.

People who experience colourism or racism, a 2019 study in the journal *Perspectives on Psychological Science* points out, are more likely to develop hypertension, psychological distress and are more prone to health-related issues. Consistent negative messaging and incidents in their life lead to their internalising shame, anxiety and fear, which may manifest in cognitive or physical stress. "With so much pressure to conform to a certain 'idea' of what is beautiful, young children really struggle to fit in and socialise, with those who don't conform getting subjected to type-

CASE STUDY

PREETI DAS | 48 |
Actor, stand-up performer and story-teller



"I was told though you're dark, you're beautiful inside"

My dark skin has always been a source of curiosity and a lot of resentment. As a teenager, I was turned down by two elite boutiques saying we don't have clothes that will suit your skin colour, please try elsewhere. The jibes cut as deep today. As an actor, only a few stereotyped roles come your way. But the terminology that industry employs is even more shocking: make-up artists are often briefed to apply 'Dalit' or 'tribal' make-up—both insinuating 'burn her skin'. Once, after a stand-up performance, amidst applause, a light-skinned lady came up to me and said, "Brilliant...though you are dark-skinned, you are beautiful inside."

There are many jokes I laugh at, though they are not funny. My husband happens to be light-skinned and the 'joke' at the time of our marriage was our children will be like a chessboard. In my interactions with children, I see a perpetuation of those biases. Dark-skinned girls have tears in their eyes when I talk of discrimination in my stories; yet, an evil or negative character will only always be dark.

–as told to Jumana Shah